



TALK_{is} CHEAP

At long last, Internet users in India are being given the option of making inexpensive calls abroad. On April 1, Internet Telephony got liberated, and it is now poised to serve a nation starved for cheap talk

The world became a smaller place for Indians on Fool's Day, and we are not joking about it. After a prolonged wait, India opened its slumbering arms to embrace a phenomenon that's transforming the way people speak to each other.

To make things clearer, imagine talking to a friend in America for hours on end and paying next to nothing for it. Imagine calls so cheap that your local ISD PCO guy shuts shop! All this and more is possible through a single tech-

nology that has enjoyed immense popularity worldwide. VoIP, short for Voice over Internet Protocol, describes a set of facilities used to carry voice transmissions over the Internet. This technology encapsulates everything one would want in a means of affordable communication.

Behind the scenes

Before the embargo on VoIP was imposed and actually implemented, you might recall using sites such as *Dialpad* and *Phonefree* to touch base with friends and contacts abroad at no cost. After the collapse of the Internet economy, sites that offered free calls to certain countries now charge a few cents a minute on calls to the same destination. With the ban on VoIP dead and gone, you can officially purchase talk time from these sites and make calls without the guilt that you are doing anything illegal. The problem is you would require an international credit card to buy them. That's an inconvenience in a country that hasn't quite caught on to the concept. Fortunately, local service providers are stepping in to bridge this gap.

In the past year, ISPs across India have been clinching tie-ups, one after the other, with foreign technology partners in an effort to bring specialised service to *desi* Netizens. The ISPs are acting as more than mere middlemen here. Think of them as local partners of the services available overseas. With a regional presence, you'll experience better service and support than you would by directly approaching an IP telephony provider abroad.

How it works

Before diving into the nitty-gritty of how Net-based calls work, let's refresh your memory and run through the process of the standard, telephone-based call.

When a call is placed through conventional PSTN (Public Switched Telephone Network) lines, a dedicated link between you and the party you are calling is established. For the duration

// Service providers getting into this market (VoIP) for quick money are in for a shock and will be wiped out //

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